

## Sex Education and Perceived Relationship Health among College Students

My research topic examines relationships between college students' pre-college sex education experiences and their perceived relationship health between sexual or romantic partners and between friends. This topic was fascinating to me because I considered my own sex education to be of high quality, but the only sex education I received occurred in middle school. I was curious to see if one's sex education experiences translate to their experiences with navigating relationships.

My research is grounded in work on communication theory, namely how individuals communicate consent and pleasure during sexual encounters. Scholars have studied how these concepts are taught—or not taught—in sex education curricula, as well as the benefits for teaching these concepts in tangent with each other. Many sex education programs emphasize the dangers of sex and focus on warning students against unwanted pregnancies and the spread of sexually transmitted infections (Connell and Elliot, 2009). Notably missing from many curricula are strategies for obtaining and recognizing enthusiastic sexual consent (Willis, Jozkowski, and Read, 2019; Beres, 2010), despite reports of young peoples' desire to learn consent-related topics (Forrest, Strange, and Oakley, 2004). Several researchers also emphasize the missing topic of sexual pleasure, and show that adolescents who are taught concepts of sexual pleasure through the lens of sex positivity experience better sexual, physical, and mental health than those who learn a danger-focused sex education (Anderson, 2013; White, Boehm, Glackin, and Bleakley, 2023; Ménard and Offman, 2009).

My qualitative research asks if individuals who had positive experiences with sex education find themselves in positive sexual or romantic relationships. To understand the types of sex education college students received, as well as how they perceived that education and how they perceive their current or past relationships, I performed in-depth interviews with three current Oberlin College students. My quantitative research complements my qualitative work with related insight. In this work, I seek to understand if there is a relationship between one's opinions on sex education being taught in schools, and their self-reported relationship health. I performed a bivariate statistical analysis of variables that operationalize those two concepts using data from the 2022 General Social Survey.

My qualitative interviews were very fun to conduct, and the stories my participants told were fascinating. I conducted all of my interviews in different locations around Oberlin, and my interviewees made each one feel unique and insightful. I was lucky that the individuals I interviewed were so willing to share their experiences about a potentially uncomfortable topic. I found that my second two interviewees talked the most, and had several expansive stories to tell. They may have talked more than my first participant because I sat in silence to allow them to gather their thoughts, which was easier for me to do after my first interview. There were some awkward moments, but my participants and I found the humor in these moments and I think this made them feel more comfortable with opening up. I kept saying "great" or "cool" when they

finished speaking, and if they had just told me about a negative experience, I would follow up with “well, not cool, sorry,” or something similar. We both found this quirk to be humorous, even when my interviewee had discussed a negative experience.

I found that my second two interviewees answered many of my questions before I even asked them. Soren, my last interviewee, was especially talkative and went into great detail about her relationships and sex education experiences before college. Because she attended two very different international schools, I also found myself asking her several follow-up questions about the differences between those experiences. I was surprised that I thought of these questions on-the-fly, but my confidence as the interviewer had increased by the time I had gotten to my third interview. Overall, I think my participants made the interviews both informative and enjoyable for all parties.

The success of my interviews may have stemmed from the questions I planned in my interview guide. Following my initial questions for establishing rapport, I asked my interviewees to describe the extent of their sex education, including how they learned topics relating to sexual intercourse, relationships, consent, and pleasure. These questions allowed me to gauge the range of experiences across participants, and the depth of my participants’ formal sex education experiences. Often, my interviewees mentioned experiences and topics that I had not considered, which led into several unplanned follow-up questions. My most useful questions pertaining to one’s sex education experiences were the topical probes, as these gave me insight into the topics my participants did *not* receive in their sex education. These probes included some of my key concepts of interest, like the extent to which discussions of consent and pleasure were parts of one’s sex education. After asking my participants all of my questions about sex education experiences, I asked my participants how they felt about the formal sex education they received. This allowed me to gauge their feelings and attitudes about their sex education, such as what was missing or what they liked. These insights are important to understand how sex education systems might be reformed to help individuals navigate healthy relationships later on in life.

Following our discussion of my interviewee’s sex education experiences, I transitioned to asking questions about relationships. I first asked my participants to describe their idea of a healthy sexual or romantic relationship. This allowed me to isolate themes that were important across participants, and led into my questions about their own relationships. Similarly to our discussion of sex education, the participants often answered my later questions within their answers to this first question. Soren and Charlie both described their own current relationships as models of healthy relationships. All of my participants brought up themes of communication and trust before I asked about these specific concepts. I was surprised to find that the question about boundaries was more difficult for my participants to answer, and that they valued ongoing communication more than firm boundary-setting. Following our discussions about romantic and sexual relationships, I transitioned to questions about healthy friendships. Following my first interview, I realized that these questions led to discussions of topics that were less pertinent to my topic of interest, as I was more interested in how individuals navigate sexual relationships than friendships. Though the discussions on friendships gave insight to how my participants

navigate non-sexual relationships, they did not add as much to my understanding of my participants' relationship health.

My interview data brings insights to the relationship between college students' sex education experiences and their experiences with sexual and romantic relationships. Interestingly, my interviewees had varying experiences with sex education, yet demonstrated shared values in their depictions of healthy relationships. They emphasized the importance of communication between sexual partners, and how this develops a healthy relationship. Soren, an international student who had separate sex education experiences in her Christian middle school and international high school, emphasizes how valuing communication contributes to her healthy relationship with her boyfriend:

I really set strong boundaries at the beginning and I was like, "okay, listen, like, I think we should be really communicative and we should talk to each other about anything and everything," like, and I like, "communication is like a big thing, but I also want you to comprehend what I'm saying. Like, I could talk to you all I want about my problems, but if you don't understand what I'm saying, and I don't understand what you're saying, then there's still a disconnect."

This value of communication was shared by Charlie, who is in a 5-year relationships with his girlfriend:

Yeah, um I've only ever had one sexual partner. Um, we like, know each other like the back of our hands. I don't think there's, between us, it's like there's never any confusion about, like, where... about how each other feels. Like it's always really important to be completely 100% on the same page, especially as far as keeping things, like, healthy.

My participants' shared the values of effective communication between their partners reflects the findings about communication theory, which suggest that teaching individuals to express and recognize consent and pleasure in sexual relationships will prepare them for healthy sexual relationships in the future.

Interestingly, my participants attributed learning these shared values of communication in relationships to different sources. Soren attributes this knowledge of sexual communication—specifically consent—to her sex education from her international school:

I had like a much better sex education experience in my high school, like at the different international school that I went to because they weren't afraid to be like, "okay, straight up, like, this is the list of all the contraceptives that you can have, and these are arranged from best to worst, and this is literally what happens and, like, also we need you to watch this video on consent and we need to talk about this consent." Like that was, like, so much better than whatever I went through in middle school. So, like, I definitely remember, like they [Christian middle school] were like, "okay, like no means no." And I was like, "okay, that's... that's what it is," but I think in high school they just expanded more upon it.

Charlie describes that much of his knowledge of communicating consent actually came from his mother, not his sex education:

I don't think anyone ever raised the, uh, question of consent until, like—I, I mean, my mom and I discussed it often, like about... especially when, when I became old enough to be like drinking and, and smoking and things like that. That, like, we really talked about, like informed consent together and like, me and my mom, like, “if you're drinking and she's drinking, like, you should not have sex, like, because you can't, you're not able to consent properly.” And so like that was something I had learned from my mother before I came to Oberlin, and obviously had the formal consent training, so I—I—I had, I had, I had learned about, like, informed consent from her.

Charlie's discussions of consent and relationships with his mother may contribute to why he finds himself in a fulfilling and happy relationship, despite the shortcomings of sex education. This suggests that sex education itself may not be the most significant factor in successfully navigating healthy relationships; rather, the topics learned (e.g. sexual consent and pleasure) may be of more importance than the source of information (Anderson, 2013; White, Boehm, Glackin, and Bleakley, 2023; Ménard and Offman, 2009).

Aside from the theme of communication and the varying ways participants learned communication strategies, an important theme that participants described throughout the interviews was how religion impacted both their sex education and their values around relationships. Candy, who feels her sex education left her feeling “extremely unprepared,” describes how religious undertones impacted her comfort in discussing sexual topics like masturbation and sexual pleasure. She describes that “because I grew up in like, a predominantly Christian area, all my friends were Christian, like I felt like that was very much a taboo subject.” Charlie describes how religion impacted the values taught by his formal sex education, despite his school being unaffiliated with religion:

Like I was raised very Catholic, which obviously has its connotations of waiting until marriage and, you know, having sex is a sin outside of marriage, obviously, and so, like, I was always kind of familiar with that it was wrong—and my town was extremely Christian, very, very Christian, like completely Christian dominated, like... it was like, it was, it was odd if you were an atheist or if you didn't go to church. Like... it was like, “oh, that's... you're allowed to do that, I guess,” you know, like especially when I was younger, because it's... everybody did... everybody just went to church on Sundays. And so that obviously bled into, like, all of our teachers, how they wanted it to go too, like all of our teachers also lived in [hometown] and, and, went to church, the same churches as us. So they were trying to put those same messages into our minds, of that it was, it was wrong to have sex and... that it's a very, it's a very serious thing.

These religious values underpinning sex education may explain the dominance of abstinence-only sex education in the United States, as described by Connell and Elliot (2009). More work may be needed to analyze how sex education with religious underpinnings may prepare students for navigating sexual relationships differently than non-religious sex education.

These interviews have provided insight to the strategies I would take if I were to continue this research. In addition to understanding the varied structures and systems of formal sex education, I would focus on building a picture of my participants' various sources of information pertaining to sex and relationships. I would continue to ask them to describe their formal sex education experiences, but I would also ask about any discussions they remember having with parents or other family members. The questions I asked about friendships were less important to understanding how my participants navigate healthy relationships, so I may discard these questions altogether. In their place, I might ask questions that give a better understanding of how my participants communicate consent and pleasure in a sexual context. When designing my original interview guide, I had trouble framing this topic in a way that would not make my participants uncomfortable, so I left it out of these interviews.

My first two participants provided insight to the continuity of their education within the same school district for elementary, middle, and high school. While this is important, I found my last participant's comparison of her two distinct educational systems to be extremely insightful. If I were to continue this research in the future, I would like to recruit participants who attended more than one school system. I believe their ability to compare different sex education experiences may have more insight to which topics and teaching strategies were beneficial and which were not. Additionally, I might look to recruit more international students to compare their educational experiences with those of individuals who grew up in the United States. I might go about this by posting recruitment ads in a wider scope and in varied spaces.

This qualitative work brings insight to the nuances, contextual factors, and motivations behind the wider statistical trends we see in my quantitative research. I found a statistically significant relationship between the variables I analyzed such that individuals who favored sex education in schools reported having higher relationship happiness with their cohabitant. My qualitative research informs this relationship by discussing factors that individuals believe contribute to healthy relationships, namely effective communication between partners. My participants described how their sex education—both formal and from family—contributed to these values and their relationship health. My quantitative work also informs my qualitative work, as my participants with healthy ongoing relationships also described favored sex education in schools, doing so through descriptions of how certain aspects of their sex education could be reformed to prepare individuals for navigating sexual and romantic relationships. As a whole, my quantitative and qualitative research can show the importance of continuing to teach sex education in schools, and how reforms to include topics of sexual communication (consent and pleasure) may bring students the necessary skills to navigate healthy sexual and romantic relationships.

## **Appendix: Interview Guide**

### **OPENING STATEMENT**

“Hi! My name is Elinor and I’m a 4th-year Sociology and Computer Science major. I’m currently conducting research for my sociological research methods class, and I appreciate your openness to being interviewed! My research focuses on Oberlin students’ experiences with sex education in middle and/or high school. If you’re willing, I would love to hear about any formal classes, topics, and your feelings about any sex education you might have received before college.

Did you get a chance to look over the IRB consent form I sent earlier?

Do you have any questions about anything included?

As part of the research process, I need to audio-record my interviews, which I store locally on my computer until I’ve completed transcription, after which I delete. In transcribing, I will remove identifying information and use a pseudonym for you and any individuals you mention. If you wish to not be recorded, I appreciate your time and we can end the interview now. Do you consent to being audio-recorded?

Some of the topics we discuss may feel personal and intimate, as I’d like to know about your experiences with sex education and relationships between friends and partners. You may decline to answer any question at any time and we can happily move to another topic. Additionally, you may decide at any time to end the interview and ask for your data not to be used, and I will delete the audio recording at that time. Does this make sense?

The consent form also contains resources for support, so feel free to reach out to those resources at any time. I don’t intend or anticipate the interview to be emotionally or mentally stressful, but those resources are there if you need at any point. Does this make sense?

Finally, before we get started I wanted to reiterate how grateful I am to receive any insight you have, and if you have specific details or stories I would appreciate hearing them. There is no such thing as talking too much; the more detail you are willing and able to share, the better. Additionally, please feel free to bring up any information you deem relevant, even if it is not directly related to the questions I ask.

Are you ready to get started?”

### **OPENING QUESTIONS**

1. What is your name, pronouns if you are comfortable, and major?
2. Why did you choose Oberlin?
  - a. What do you like about it?
  - b. What are you involved with on campus? (Student orgs, sports, performances, work, etc.)

### **KEY QUESTIONS**

3. Can you describe where you grew up and the school system(s) you attended before Oberlin?
  - a. What did you like about your K-12 schools? Dislike?
  - b. What kinds of activities were you into?

### ***SEX EDUCATION***

“Now I am going to ask you about your experiences with sex education before attending college. I appreciate any details you remember, and if there is anything you are uncomfortable answering or if you can’t remember, please feel free to let me know, and we can skip the question.”

4. Did you have a memorable moment where you learned what sexual intercourse was?
  - If yes: Can you describe this moment?
  - If no: That's OK! Can you describe the kinds of resources that taught you what sexual intercourse was?
5. Did you receive a form of health or sex education through your school?
  - If yes: Go to question 6
  - If no: Did you receive any non-formal sex education (from friends, parents, media, etc?), and what was this like? (Go to question 7, replace all following instances of “formal sex education” with “informal sex-education”)
6. How many semesters/years did you receive sex education, and what years did those take place?
7. Can you describe any topics you remember being taught?
8. Can you describe any questions you had that were not addressed in your formal sex education?
9. How did your formal sex education navigate concepts of...
  - a. sexual consent?
  - b. Communication between partners?

- c. Non-heteronormativity?
  - d. pleasure?
10. Overall, how did you feel about your sex education?
- a. To what extent do you think it prepared you to navigate future sexual relationships?
  - b. What do you think should be taught in sex education before college?

### ***ROMANTIC RELATIONSHIPS***

“Thank you! Now, I am going to ask some questions about your relationships between romantic partners, if applicable. If you are not comfortable answering a question, please feel free to let me know and we can skip it.”

11. When you think about a healthy relationship between romantic or sexual partners, what does this look like?
12. Have you ever considered anyone to be a romantic or sexual partner?
- a. If yes: Continue to question 13
  - b. If no: Continue to question 16

Have/had partner(s):

13. Can you describe your own relationships with previous or current sexual or romantic partners in terms of this definition?
14. To what extent do/did you trust your partner?
- a. How much personal information about yourself do you share with them?
  - b. How much personal information about themselves do they share with you?
15. What kinds of boundaries do/did you have with your partner(s)? What kinds of boundaries do/did they have with you?

Ask everyone:

16. How confident do you feel in your ability to communicate your desires and boundaries to a potential partner?
- a. What contributes to these feelings?
17. Do you have any thoughts about how your sex education did (or didn't) impact the way you interact with partners?



### ***UNHEALTHY ROMANTIC RELATIONSHIPS***

“Thank you! Now I have a few questions that are about unhealthy relationships, broadly speaking. This could range from a partner making an offensive comment to a partner engaging in physical harm. Again, I want to remind you that we can skip these questions if you prefer. Would you like to hear the questions? There are two of them.”

18. Have you experienced discomfort in a sexual or romantic encounter and felt unable to advocate for yourself?
  - If yes: Can you describe this experience if you are willing?
  - If no: Continue
19. Have you experienced a sexual encounter in which you believe your partner was uncomfortable or unhappy?
  - If yes: Can you describe this experience if you are willing?
    - a. How did your partner communicate this?
    - b. How did you navigate the situation?
  - If no: Continue

### ***RELATIONSHIPS WITH FRIENDS***

“Thank you for this insight! Now, I am going to ask a few questions about your relationships between friends. Again, if you are not comfortable answering a question, please feel free to let me know and we can skip it.”

20. When you think about a healthy relationship between friends, what does this look like?
21. Can you describe your own relationships with your friends in terms of this definition?
22. To what extent do you trust your friends?
  - a. How much personal information about yourself do you share with them?
  - b. How much personal information about themselves do they share with you?
23. If you had an issue come up with a friend, how comfortable would you be addressing it with them directly?
  - a. How would you handle it?
24. What kinds of boundaries do you have with your friends? What kinds of boundaries do they have with you?
  - a. How do you feel about these boundaries? To what extent do your friends accept and follow your boundaries?

## **CLOSING QUESTIONS**

25. Now, please think about a relationship in your life that you really like. It can be with anyone. What do you like about it? Why does the relationship work so well?
26. I've asked you a lot of questions about sex education and relationships today. Is there anything else that you think is relevant to these topics that we haven't covered that you would like to share?

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